

intensify as domestic drug makers prepare to enter the GLP-1 market following the expiry of Novo Nordisk's key Semaglutide formulation and delivery patent in India in March 2026.

Dr Reddy's Laboratories is preparing to launch Semaglutide in India, select emerging markets and Canada, having received marketing authorisation in India, with rollouts planned over the coming quarters. Sun Pharma has also secured approval from the Drugs Controller General of India to manufacture and market a generic Semaglutide injection for chronic weight management, to be sold under the brand Noveltreat.

M.V. Ramana, CEO of Branded Markets (India and Emerging Markets) at Dr Reddy's Laboratories, says: "Semaglutide across multiple markets is an important focus area for us. This is not a category limited only to weight loss. There is growing evidence across diabetes, obesity, cardiovascular and other indications. It is a class of compounds that will remain relevant."

While GLP-1 drugs have delivered strong weight-loss outcomes, concerns around gastrointestinal side effects, muscle loss and long-term persistence are pushing drug makers to design therapies that are more durable, better tolerated by the human system and easier to use.

This has led companies to explore multi-hormone drugs, combining GLP-1 with GIP, glucagon or amylin, muscle-preserving add-ons, oral options beyond injectables, and broader use across diabetes, cardiovascular, kidney and liver diseases. GIP stands for Gastric Inhibitory Polypeptide, a hormone secreted by the small intestine that stimulates insulin secretion.

GLP-1 drugs work by mimicking a naturally occurring gut hor-

WHERE THE MARKET IS HEADING

MULTI-HORMONE DRUGS:

DUAL AND TRIPLE AGONISTS COMBINING GLP-1 WITH GIP, GLUCAGON OR AMYLIN

MUSCLE-PRESERVING ADD-ONS: PAIRING WEIGHT-LOSS DRUGS WITH THERAPIES THAT PROTECT LEAN MASS

ORAL OPTIONS: EXPANDING ACCESS BEYOND INJECTABLES

BEYOND OBESITY: POSITIONING DRUGS ACROSS DIABETES, HEART, KIDNEY AND LIVER DISEASE



mone that regulates blood sugar and appetite, helping patients feel fuller for longer and reducing food intake. Many of the newer therapies are built on this mechanism by combining GLP-1 with other hormones involved in metabolism.

LILLY'S PLANS

Lilly is organising its post-GLP-1 pipeline around precision medicine, multi-pathway therapies and a broader disease footprint as competition mounts.

Winslow Tucker, President and General Manager of Lilly's India chapter, says the company's next wave of innovation is focused on "tailoring therapies to patient subgroups through biomarkers and precision medicine to maximise patient impact."

Lilly's research pipeline includes multiple incretin-based molecules in clinical development across a range of diseases. Incretins are metabolic gut hormones released after meals to stimulate insulin secretion.

"Lilly is a leader in incretin development, and we have a portfolio of several incretin molecules in our pipeline that are currently in clinical development potentially for a variety of diseases," says Tucker.

The company is also advancing work on multi-hormone combinations as part of its longer-term metabolic portfolio. "By 2030, cardiometabolic diseases like obesity, diabetes and cardiovascular disease could affect one third of adults globally," Tucker warns.

Lilly is sequencing oral and injectable therapies based on patient needs and real-world use. "With distinct mechanisms, formulations and routes of administration, oral and injectable therapies may serve different patient preferences and clinical scenarios," says Tucker.